

A boost for shelters but with changes

Mass. lawmakers’ deal would further reduce time families could stay

By Matt Stout and Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts lawmakers struck a deal Tuesday to pump \$425 million into the state’s emergency shelter system while dramatically tightening the number of homeless and migrant families the state could house — and for how long — in a bid to rein in the mounting cost of the program.

The agreement unveiled by House and Senate leaders Tuesday, and approved soon after in the House, would shorten the amount of time families can stay in the emergency shelter system from nine months to six months.

It also seeks to cut the number of families allowed in the system by the end of the year from the current cap of 7,500 to 4,000 for all of 2026.

The legislation was quickly shuttled to the House floor later Tuesday, where it passed along party lines with no debate. The Democrat-led Senate is expected to vote on the bill on Wednesday.

The final bill closely mirrors versions that previously passed both chambers, and is designed to slash costs in the cash-starved shelter program while reshaping the right-to-shelter

SHELTERS, Page A6

Vocational school rebuild would come at a huge price

Boston to seek state help on Madison Park funding

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

Generations of students have cycled through Boston’s lone vocational high school, enduring periods of neglect, failed leadership, and broken promises until finally a beacon of hope emerged in 2023 with Mayor Michelle’s Wu proposal to rebuild the Roxbury campus, even doubling it in size.

Now the price of that ambitious vision is rounding into view: a staggering \$700 million.

While the cost of building new schools in Massachusetts has escalated rapidly in recent years, the recent estimate would make the revamped Madison Park Technical Vocational High School the most expensive in state history. And should the city proceed with its current options, it could end up costing much more, since the start of construction is likely several years off.

“Madison Park is a monster project,” said Greg Maynard of the Boston Policy Institute, who follows school construction closely. “Madison Park is a really old school, it’s in an urban environment, and it’s just expensive to build things in cities. . . . There 100 percent could be cost escalations, especially with the tariffs that

MADISON PARK, Page A7

Learning the hardest way

Some immigrant families keep children out of school for fear of ICE raids



PAT GREEN-HOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio, Christopher Huffaker, and John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

LYNN — Esperanza and her two daughters fled the violence and hunger the family endured in the western highlands of Guatemala in the hopes that one day the girls could freely study and grow up out of harm’s way.

But on Monday morning, Esperanza’s fourth-grade daughter clutched the fence outside of her Lynn elementary school in a moment of anxiousness that had become common for her since President Trump’s inauguration.

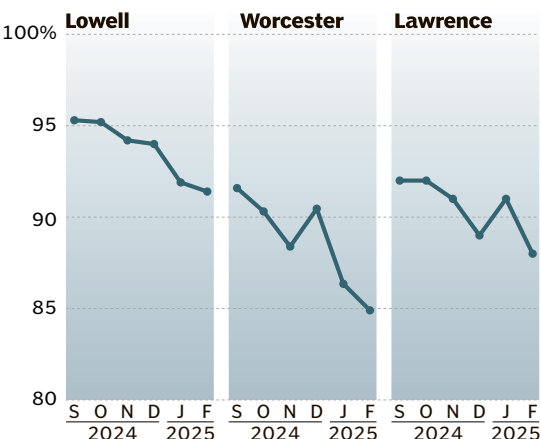
“I think that they’re going to deport us,” the 9-year-old said in Spanish. “It scares me.”

Esperanza, an asylum-seeker who asked the Globe to withhold her last name and the names of her children because of deportation concerns, said she kept her daughter home at least once in the past month over fears that immigration officials would arrest the family. Her family is living in the country without legal authorization. The 9-year-old frequently worries that while she’s in class, immigration agents will separate the family. It’s a fear they all share. On Monday, her 3-year-old sister began sobbing

STUDENTS, Page A4

School attendance since Trump’s inauguration

Some districts, including Worcester, reported dramatic declines on Jan. 21 and 22. Some of the declines may be attributed to weather, illness, and other typical causes of seasonal fluctuation.



SOURCE: School districts, February through Feb. 14
CHRISTOPHER HUFFAKER/GLOBE STAFF

Esperanza, an asylum-seeker from Guatemala, said she kept her older daughter home at least once in the past month. The children, 9 and 3, are alarmed at the possibility of deportation.

MINERAL DEAL

Ukraine has agreed to turn over revenue from some of its resources to the United States. **A3.**

WU’S MESSAGE

The mayor sought to reassure immigrant residents about Boston’s welcoming policies. **B1.**

TARGETING DOGE

Resigning civil service workers say key services are being cut. **A4.**

‘House Republicans moved Congress closer to delivering on President Trump’s full America First agenda, not just parts of it.’

HOUSE SPEAKER
MIKE JOHNSON

GOP holds together as House advances budget resolution

By Catie Edmondson, Andrew Duehren, Maya C. Miller, and Robert Jimison
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The House on Tuesday narrowly passed a Republican budget resolution that calls for \$4.5 trillion in tax cuts and a \$2 trillion reduction in federal spending over a decade, clearing the way for major elements of President Trump’s domestic agenda.

The nearly party-line vote of 217-215 teed up a bitter fight within the GOP over which federal programs to slash to partially finance a huge tax cut that would provide its biggest benefits to rich Americans.

It came after a head-spinning hour in which Republican leaders tried to put down a revolt among conservatives who wanted deeper spending cuts, failed to do so, canceled the budget vote, and then reversed course min-

BUDGET, Page A5

Ex-inmates struggle to adjust to the outside



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

William Allen, who served decades in prison, said that after his release, “I was lost.”

State taking steps to provide more support

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

Miguel Vazquez compares the experience of leaving prison to getting on a roller coaster in the dark.

At the end of 2012, he was sent to a pre-release program in Boston, where he had to find a job with no cellphone and no knowledge of the city. He was later moved to a halfway house in Dorchester for recovering addicts, despite not having a history of substance abuse. Then moved again.

Finally, after serving more than 18 years for a gang-related homicide in Springfield, Vazquez was suddenly released on a September day in 2014. He was a free man with \$647 to his

name, a prison ID, a few trash bags full of belongings — and nowhere to go.

“Life is moving 1,000 times faster in society than it was behind the prison wall,” Vazquez said. “They do not prepare you.”

Reentering society after spending years, sometimes decades, in prison is daunting. People have been isolated and may have lost connections with family and friends. They come out with little money and a criminal record that makes it difficult to find work.

In recent years, prison systems across the country have been trying to fill this gap, expanding their focus

REENTRY, Page A7

Eye-popping gas bills have homeowners wondering what’s going on, and three key factors are to blame. The Fine Print, **B5.**

DIY enthusiasts will soon have to look elsewhere for their fabric supplies with the news that Joann is closing all its stores. **B5.**

Making soup is a great way to get rid of food about to go bad in your refrigerator, without wasting it. **G1.**



Runny in the banks

Wednesday: Even warmer. High 49-54. Low 34-39.

Thursday: Warmer still. High 53-58. Low 36-41.

Sunrise: 6:24 Sunset: 5:30

Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

VOL. 307, NO. 57

Suggested retail price
\$4.00

